



LEADERSHIP

AI discoverability: the case for acting now

A short board paper setting out what AI search means for the destination, the risk of waiting, and the resourcing decision in front of us.

PREPARED FOR [ORGANISATION] LEADERSHIP • WITH THE DIGITAL TOURISM THINK TANK

The ask. That the board agrees to treat AI discoverability as standing programme infrastructure, adopt a common standard across the destination, and resource the work set out in section four. The detail follows; the decision is the point.

01 The context

56%

of travellers used AI for at least one trip in the past year, more than double 2024.

Phocuswright, 2026

78%

of AI users booked based mainly on an AI recommendation.

TakeUp, 2026

fastest

behavioural shift the travel industry has seen in a decade.

Phocuswright, 2026

Visitors increasingly ask an AI assistant where to go and what to do, and act on the answer. The assistant composes a single response and names a handful of places. This is the fastest shift in traveller behaviour the industry has tracked in a decade, and it changes where the decision is made: in the answer, before the visitor reaches our channels or our partners' sites.

02 What is at stake for us

Two risks, one opportunity. The first risk is absence: if the destination and its businesses are not understood and trusted by these systems, we simply do not appear at the decisive moment. The second is concentration: assistants lean on the same well known names, which can crowd out the wider destination and deepen pressure on a few sites. The opportunity is the mirror of both. Done well, this is how lesser known but excellent businesses earn a place in the answer, spreading visibility and demand across the destination.

03 The proposal

A phased programme, owned centrally, that brings the destination and its industry up to a defined standard and keeps them there.

Phase	Focus	Outcome
Foundations	A common standard, the priority questions, the core fixes on our own estate.	A baseline and a shared bar for the destination.
Build	Schema, content and entity work, and supporting industry to the standard.	More of the destination understood and recommendable.
Measure	Tracking how we appear, and acting on the gaps each quarter.	A maintained capability, not a one-off push.

The programme is supported by three things already in hand: a standard for industry to build to, a procurement discipline for agencies and suppliers, and a set of member tools for implementation and measurement.

04 What we are asking for

Modest, and framed as infrastructure rather than a campaign.

-  A named owner accountable for AI discoverability across teams.
-  A defined share of content, web and insight time, rather than new headcount in the first instance.
-  A small budget for tooling and for supporting industry adoption.
-  Agreement to the standard and the procurement discipline, so spend is protected.

DTTT POSITION

Fund this as infrastructure. The cost of absence compounds quietly: every quarter we are not understood by these systems is share of attention conceded, and it does not come back on its own. The spend to hold a place in the answer is small against the visibility at stake.

05 Risks of not acting

- Gradual, unmeasured loss of visibility as more visitors decide inside the answer.
- A destination represented by a few names, with the long tail invisible.
- Industry left to face the shift alone, unevenly and often badly.
- A harder, costlier catch up later, once the gap is visible in the numbers.

Prepared with the Digital Tourism Think Tank as part of the [organisation] AI Discoverability programme. This is strategic guidance, not financial advice. Adapt the bracketed fields and the resourcing ask to your own context before tabling.